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Afida.com: Five-Year Growth Plan (mid-2026 to mid-2031)

Prepared 2026-07-06 by Laurent, revised 2026-07-07. An honest plan, not a pitch deck. Numbers from live Datafa.st, Stripe-backed order data, and GSC; industry context from the UK B2B packaging market.

Scope: this plan covers **afida.com, the online store, only**. Afida also serves offline trade clients with accounts and repeat orders; that book is not measured here, and nothing in this document is a statement about Afida's overall financial position. "Revenue", "growth" and "break-even" below always mean the online channel. A second web property already exists, **customer.afida.com** (a separate trade-portal app with per-customer price lists and net-30 invoicing); where this plan says "trade channel" it means the store and that portal working together, though the \$1 revenue baselines are store-only.

0. The one-paragraph version

The afida.com store today is a ~£3k/month channel growing fast off a tiny base, and the money currently spent on it (Laurent's retainer plus the ads agency) exceeds what the channel itself returns. The honest five-year path is not "do more SEO". It is a staged change of what the store is: first prove online acquisition and repeat-purchase economics as a niche eco-packaging shop (2026-27), then make the store a **trade-account channel** where cafés and restaurants reorder monthly, a motion Afida's offline side already proves customers want (2027-28), then attack **margin** with custom-print and own-brand product on the proven bestsellers (2028-30).

Done well, afida.com is a £500k-800k/yr channel at ~40% blended gross margin by mid-2031, contributing ~£120-170k a year once development has stepped down to maintenance. Done half-heartedly, it plateaus around £100-150k/yr as a site that roughly pays for its own upkeep. Both outcomes are on the table; the difference is Afida leadership's appetite for the trade/own-brand phases, which need leadership time and some working capital, not more code.

1. Where afida.com actually is (July 2026)

The numbers (online store only; offline trade orders appear nowhere below)

Datafa.st tracking began 2026-01-20, so "trailing 12 months" is really ~5.5 months of data:

Month (2026)	Visitors	Payments	Revenue
Jan (partial)	1,095	7	£674
Feb	2,928	2	£235
Mar	1,213	7	£1,386
Apr	858	3	£434
May	1,491	17	£1,813
Jun	3,312	33	£2,756
Jul (6 days)	344	7	£891

- **Run-rate:** June was the best month on record; July is pacing ~£4.5k/month, though 6 days of data proves nothing. Call the honest current run-rate **£2.5-3.5k/month, trending up**.
- **AOV ~£85-110.** Conversion ~0.7-1.0% headline, but diluted: ~36-42% of traffic is non-UK and cannot buy (UK-only shipping). UK-only conversion is materially better.
- **Repeat/direct is the profit engine.** Returning visitors reached ~15-24% in Jun/Jul and direct is the #1 revenue source. This is the seed of the online trade-account channel.
- **Demand shape (Mar-Jun order data):** Vegware cold cups are the broadest seller (frequency), double-wall hot cups and Bella Pots drive revenue. Classic café/deli consumables. The buyers behave like trade buyers even though we treat them like consumers.
- **SEO position:** 62% of clicks are brand; the blog generates 74% of impressions and ~£0 revenue; every commercial head term sits on Google page 2-3. One proven B2B template ("sustainable packaging for restaurants", position ~2.8) converts.
- **What the store doesn't see:** Afida's offline trade clients order outside the site, so none of the numbers above include them. Their order sizes and reorder cycles are the best calibration data available for the Phase 2 targets; worth pulling from the offline records early. Channel reality (leadership, 2026-07-07): only a handful of trade clients use the customer.afida.com portal; most order through hospitality procurement platforms (Procure Wizard, Rekki, MarketMan) or by email, hotels especially. The stated blocker is having to use yet another tool.

The uncomfortable part

- **Fully costed, the online channel runs at a loss.** Laurent's retainer (~£2,000-2,500/month) plus the agency (~£500/month) is ~£30-36k/year against ~£35k/year of online revenue at maybe 30-35% gross margin, i.e. ~£11-12k/year of channel gross profit. The gap is an investment, and it is fine at this stage, but the plan must grow the channel into its cost base. Channel break-even on current costs needs roughly **£8-10k/month online revenue at 35% GM**. The retainer is also not a fixed cost in perpetuity; it is sized for the build phases and

steps down later (see the cost-base note in §5). (A statement about the store, not about Afida overall; the offline book sits outside this plan.)

- **The constraint is demand and margin structure, not software.** The Rails app is already ahead of the business (bespoke checkout, search, delivery promise, analytics plumbing). More engineering, by itself, adds nearly nothing now. The engineering budget must shift toward things that acquire and retain trade customers.
 - **Afida buys from distributors, not manufacturers.** Vegware, Planetware, Edenware are manufacturers; Afida's supply runs through at least one distribution layer. On identical branded SKUs that every competitor also stocks, price is transparent and the margin ceiling is low. This is the structural margin problem the plan must eventually fix.
 - **Sample sizes are tiny.** 76 payments in six months. Every trend claim above could still be noise; the plan below front-loads cheap experiments precisely because we cannot yet trust the averages.
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2. The market Afida is playing in

Tailwinds (real, regulatory, multi-year)

- The England single-use plastics ban (Oct 2023: plastic cutlery, plates, EPS containers) permanently shifted foodservice demand toward paper, bagasse, PLA and wood. Scotland and Wales are further along. Enforcement and scope keep ratcheting.
- The **Plastic Packaging Tax** (>£200/tonne, rising with inflation) and **packaging EPR fees** (invoicing began 2025) make conventional plastic structurally more expensive every year. Buyers churn suppliers when this hits their price lists; churn events are acquisition opportunities.
- **Simpler Recycling** (business food-waste separation, phased from March 2025) strengthens the case for compostables in workplaces and hospitality.
- Hospitality buyers increasingly need a sustainability story for their own customers. "Certified compostable, next-day, with a straight answer about what actually composts" is a real value proposition; most competitors' content is beige and evasive. Afida's deadpan voice and honest education angle is a genuine differentiator here.

Headwinds (equally real)

- **Competition is brutal and price-led.** Nisbets, Bunzl-owned distributors, Catering24, Alliance Online, GM Packaging, Takeaway Packaging, plus Amazon Business. On a branded Vegware SKU, Afida competes with a dozen sellers of the identical item; Google Shopping makes the price comparison one click away. A small player cannot win a price war and must not try.
- **Compostables face a credibility problem.** Industrial-composting access in the UK is patchy; Defra's long-term position on PLA is unsettled; a future policy shift against PLA cold cups (a current bestseller category) is a real material-mix risk. Mitigation: never let one material family exceed ~40% of revenue; keep bagasse/paper/wood strength.
- **Shipping bulky, light goods is expensive** relative to item value. Small consumer-sized orders barely carry their own carriage. The economics only really work at trade order sizes (£150+) or pallet wholesale.

Where a small player wins

Not on price, not on range breadth. The winnable games are: **niche authority** (eco-only, honest education, official-stockist status), **service** (samples, next-day, a human answering), **retention**

(trade accounts that reorder monthly with zero acquisition cost), and **margin capture** (custom print, own-brand). This plan is built around exactly those four.

3. The strategic thesis

afida.com stops being “a small online shop that sells eco packaging to whoever shows up” and becomes “the self-serve ordering channel for a few hundred UK cafés, restaurants and food businesses”, with owned margin on its top products. Afida already has offline trade clients who reorder; the store’s job is to make that motion self-serve, scalable and measurable, and to win accounts the offline side would never reach.

Three convictions behind it:

1. **Revenue quality beats revenue quantity.** A café spending £200/month for three years is worth ~£7k; a one-off consumer order is worth £90. Afida’s own offline book already proves the behaviour; the store just doesn’t capture it yet. Everything (SEO templates, samples, email, site features) should funnel toward opening and keeping trade relationships.
 2. **Margin is made in sourcing, not in the shopping cart.** Reselling branded SKUs through a distributor caps gross margin around 30-35%. Custom print and own-brand import move the ceiling to 45-60% on the SKUs that matter. That is the difference between a hobby and a business at this scale.
 3. **The custom Rails app is a moat only if pointed at B2B.** Trade pricing tiers, credit-account checkout, one-click reorder, quote requests: these are expensive to bolt onto a template shop and cheap for us. Build the features competitors’ Shopify themes can’t match, and stop polishing the consumer surface.
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4. The five-year arc

Phases, not calendar years; each phase has an entry condition, and later phases only make sense if the earlier ones prove out. Revenue figures are the **central** scenario (see §6 for conservative/stretch).

Phase 1 (now → mid-2027): prove the engine. Target: £6-8k/month exit run-rate (~£60-80k/yr)

This is the already-agreed H2-2026 strategy, extended, with one addition (the trade wedge). Nothing new-and-shiny.

1. **Accountability first.** Reconcile the agency’s £500/month against Stripe orders; fix the Datafast purchase-goal watch items; produce the monthly blended scoreboard. Kill or redirect the spend if it doesn’t pay back. (In flight.)
2. **Commercial SEO to page 1.** Continue Moves 1-3: category/collection depth, the “[product] for restaurants/cafés” template, blog→shop CTAs, meta-CTR fixes on the 5 high-impression posts. Measure at the ~2026-07-17 GSC pull and every 4 weeks after. Blog gets **no** new investment beyond CTR/internal-link fixes.
3. **Retention flows that match consumable buying.** Klaviyo replenishment reminders timed to each category’s real reorder cycle (cups ~4-6 weeks for a small café), post-purchase cross-sell (cups→lids→napkins), win-back. This is the cheapest revenue in the whole plan.
4. **The trade wedge (new, the one addition):** a proper /trade page + trade sign-up on **afida.com**, funnelling into the trade portal that already exists (customer.afida.com: per-customer price lists, net-30). VAT invoices, free samples, a named contact, 5-10% off first

trade order, and a “set up a standing order” promise. Route every samples request and every second purchase from the same business into it. Success metric: **number of accounts with 2+ orders**, reported monthly next to revenue.

- Do not bet on migrating the existing offline clients: they already have the portal available and only a handful use it; the rest order through their procurement platforms or by email and are happy there. The wedge is for **net-new** trade customers won on the web, who self-select for web ordering. One cheap diagnostic is still worth running: ask a few existing clients what would make the portal worth using, since the stated blocker is “having to use” another tool.

5. **Ship the samples→account loop.** Samples are already free (customer pays delivery). Add the follow-up sequence: sample despatched → 5 days later “how did they land” email → 14 days later first-order discount. Track sample-to-order conversion; it is the single most informative funnel number for Phase 2.

Engineering this phase: trade sign-up + account flagging, reorder shortcut (“buy this order again”), Klaviyo event wiring, nothing else new. Laurent’s mix stays ~60% dev / 40% growth.

Exit condition for Phase 2: ≥25 businesses with 2+ orders, repeat share ≥30% of revenue, and a proven read on whether paid ads return >1x. If June’s growth was noise and revenue is still <£4k/month by mid-2027, stop and re-diagnose before spending anything on Phase 2.

Phase 2 (mid-2027 → late 2028): become a trade supplier. Target: £15-18k/month exit (~£180-220k/yr)

The shift from shop to supplier. Two revenue legs get added:

1. **Trade accounts as a product.**

- The core features already exist on customer.afida.com (per-customer price lists, net-30 invoicing), so the work is **adoption and unification**, not building: funnel web-won accounts into the portal, close the gaps that keep clients on email (one-click reorder, standing orders), and decide deliberately how the store and the portal share the customer record. Owning this stack is still the differentiator vs the Shopify crowd; it is just further along than this plan originally assumed.
- **Standing orders / subscriptions** on consumables (the same 10 SKUs dominate reorders). Even 30 cafés on a £150/month standing order is £54k/yr of zero-CAC revenue.
- **Meet the platform-locked segment where it lives.** A lot of trade customers (hotels especially) order only through procurement platforms (Procure Wizard, Rekki, MarketMan). Evaluate getting Afida listed as a supplier on one or two of them: fees, catalogue/integration requirements, who owns the customer relationship and the data. If the economics work, this is a distribution channel no feature on Afida’s own sites can substitute for; if they don’t, better to know early and stop wondering.
- Light outbound, done by Afida leadership or a part-time person, not Laurent: every inbound sample request, every local café opening (new food-hygiene registrations are public data), every lapsed account gets a call or visit. At this scale, 5 good conversations a week outperforms any ad budget.

2. **Custom print for end customers (no capex).** Branded cups are the classic wedge into a hospitality account and carry 45-60% gross margin, and the supply side already exists: Afida has a print partner at good rates. The job is productising and marketing the service on afida.com, not finding a printer; the blog already ranks for “custom printed coffee cups small orders”, so there is proven search demand. A branded-cup customer almost always becomes a full packaging account. **Check the Brand Brothers overlap with Afida leadership first:** if brandbrothers.co.uk is meant to be the custom-print venture, decide

deliberately whether print revenue lives there or in Afida, and cross-sell either way rather than building it twice.

3. **Channel hygiene:** launch Google Shopping properly (feed exists conceptually in the Ads design doc), keep the agency only if Phase 1 proved it, and consider Amazon Business **only** for a handful of own-brand SKUs later (Phase 3); on branded resale SKUs Amazon is a margin shredder and a distraction.

Cost base honesty: somewhere in this phase, fulfilment stops fitting in a spare room. Budget for either a part-time packer + small unit or a 3PL at roughly 8-12% of revenue. Net margin dips before it improves; plan for it rather than being surprised.

On own-brand, this phase deliberately does nothing except **build and measure velocity** (see §5.1): leadership's position is that there is no intermediate step worth paying for, so the phase's contribution is compounding per-SKU volume toward the import thresholds and shipping the velocity report that watches them.

Exit condition for Phase 3: ≥80-100 active trade accounts, repeat share ≥45%, custom print doing ≥£3k/month, and at least one SKU approaching its import threshold on the velocity report (leadership's benchmark: ~100k units a quarter for a cup line, across online + offline).

Phase 3 (2028 → 2030): own the margin. Target: £30-40k/month exit (~£400-500k/yr), blended GM to ~40%

1. **Own-brand ("Afida" label) on the proven top 15-20 SKUs.** Double-wall hot cups, PLA/paper cold cups, kraft containers, napkins, straws: exactly what the bestseller data already shows. Import direct from audited manufacturers (EN 13432 / home-compost certification where claimed, plastic-tax documentation in order), following the direct-import path in §5.1: plain retail units, Afida-branded outer cartons. Gross margin on own-brand typically 50-60% vs 30-35% on branded resale.
 - Working capital: expect £15-30k tied up per ordering cycle initially, before it pays back. This is Afida leadership's call and the plan's single biggest ask. Start with 3-5 SKUs, one mixed container or UK-consolidated order, not a range launch.
 - Keep Vegware as the premium branded option alongside; official-stockist status still earns search authority and trust.
2. **Shift the SEO machine to own-brand terms.** Category pages now sell Afida-label first with branded alternatives, which also ends the price-comparison death match on identical SKUs.
3. **Wholesale/pallet tier** for the biggest accounts (case and pallet pricing, pallet freight). Low glamour, high AOV, decent margin at own-brand cost.
4. **Custom print economics review:** if customer print revenue exceeds ~£5k/month, revisit terms with the existing partner (committed volume, or in-house capacity if the numbers ever justify it).

Engineering: stock/lot tracking, supplier POs, pallet shipping rates, trade portal polish. Laurent's mix by now ~30% dev / 70% growth-analytics-sourcing support, and from here the dev retainer starts stepping down toward maintenance (see the cost-base note in §5); the feature surface is largely built.

Phase 4-5 (2030 → mid-2031): compound. Target: £55-70k/month (~£650-800k/yr)

No new model, just depth: more accounts (outbound + referral incentives), a second own-brand wave, possibly a narrow Amazon/marketplace presence for own-brand only, possibly Ireland/EU shipping if own-brand margins can absorb it (revisit the 40% of traffic we currently waste). The honest expectation is that growth **decelerates** in percentage terms as the base

grows; the compounding asset is the trade-account book and the own-brand margin, not any single channel.

5. The margin plan (separate from the revenue plan, because it matters more)

Lever	When	GM impact	Cost/risk
Shipping recovery: raise free-carriage threshold, nudge AOV with case sizes	Now	+2-4pts net	Slight conversion risk on small orders; acceptable, small orders barely pay anyway
Price optimisation on low-elasticity SKUs (lids, napkins, portion pots)	Now	+1-3pts	Needs unit-price display honesty (already the design direction)
Kill loss-making order shapes (tiny orders under carriage cost) via minimum order value or price floor	2026	+1-2pts	May cost some consumer orders; fine, they're not the business
Custom print (brokered → committed volume)	2027-28	45-60% GM on that revenue	Lead-time complaints, artwork admin
Buy better: distributor terms at volume, or direct manufacturer accounts as volume qualifies	2027+	+3-5pts on resale	Needs consolidated ordering discipline
Own-brand import on top 15-20 SKUs	2028+	50-60% GM on that revenue; blended GM to ~40-45%	£15-30k working capital, certification diligence, stock risk, MOQ commitment

Blended target: ~30-35% GM today → **~38-40% by 2029** → **42-45% by 2031** if own-brand reaches 40-50% of revenue. At £700k revenue and 42% GM, gross profit is ~£295k; after fulfilment (~10%), maintenance-level development, tools and ads, net is plausibly **£120-170k/yr**. That is the realistic prize for the channel, not a startup outcome. It also builds real enterprise value: distribution businesses trade at 3-5x EBITDA, and a documented, growing online ordering channel is exactly what an acquirer of Afida would pay up for, which matters for the profit-share arrangement.

The cost-base note (development is a build cost, not a forever cost). The dev retainer (~£2-2.5k/month today) is sized for the build phases: the trade-account features, subscriptions and portal work in Phases 1-2 are the last major engineering programme this plan needs. From Phase 3 the app's feature surface stabilises and development steps down to maintenance,

on the order of a day or two a month, with Laurent's long-term alignment coming from the profit share rather than billed hours. The £120-170k net figure above therefore carries roughly £10-12k/yr of maintenance development, not a full retainer. Anyone stress-testing the model can flex that line; even the conservative full-retainer version still nets ~£100-150k.

5.1 Own-brand sourcing in practice (revised 2026-07-07 after leadership review)

An earlier draft proposed a "Tier 1" step: paying UK importers to print the Afida brand onto their stocked retail units (researched in docs/reports/tier1-white-label-playbook.md, now superseded). Afida leadership rejected it, for a reason the desk research missed: **that service exists for end customers who want their logo on a cup, not for suppliers.** The trade convention for a distributor's own label is plain retail units with the brand on the **outer boxes and stamps**, brought in by the distributor itself; Enviropack, a supplier Afida has done plenty of business with, runs exactly this model. Paying another distributor's print margin to brand retail units adds cost without adding the thing own-brand exists to add: margin. Vegware stays on the shelf throughout as the premium branded option; official-stockist status keeps earning search authority and trust while the own label grows underneath it.

A follow-up leadership conversation (same day) settled the rest of the path, and the plan adopts it wholesale:

- **There is no intermediate sourcing step.** Anything between reselling stocked lines and importing directly is too expensive to move margin. Until a product earns its container, it is business as usual with the current suppliers; most of the trade (PPP included) sells white-labelled or random-brand imports, and that is normal.
- **Own-brand triggers per SKU, on velocity.** Leadership's working example: order ~100k black 12oz ripple cups in Afida outer boxes once that line is selling ~100k units every ~3 months. Bulk is what buys the margin; the outer-carton branding comes with it. Below those numbers "it just doesn't make sense financially".
- **The model is already proven at real scale: Afida imports its own straws.** Typical order ~1 million units (~500k per size); the fibre lines sell through at roughly 100k/month, slower than the ~3-month sell-outs when the line launched (focus moved to other products; competition strengthened). The mechanics (buying big, holding stock until it sells) are understood in-house; extending to more lines is a working-capital and velocity question, not a capability question.
- **Thresholds are per product and negotiable, not fixed.** Lower quantities can be bought at worse prices ("depends on products"), so the velocity report should carry a per-line threshold, not one global number.

What the online channel contributes to that doctrine:

1. **Build the velocity.** Everything in Phases 1-2 (trade accounts, standing orders, commercial SEO, samples) exists to compound per-SKU volume toward those import thresholds.
2. **Instrument the decision.** A per-SKU velocity report: trailing-90-day units per line against its import threshold, so "is it worth it yet" becomes a dashboard read instead of a feeling. Cheap to build, with one catch: to be meaningful it must include the offline book's volumes, so it needs a feed from wherever offline orders are recorded.
3. **De-risk the container when it comes.** The due-diligence kit below, salvaged from the superseded playbook research.

When a SKU earns its container: the de-risk kit. Retail units stay plain per the trade convention; the Afida brand rides on the outer cartons, which cost little to print and read as professional. Sequencing still matters: forgiving commodity lines (napkins, kraft containers,

wooden cutlery, bags) make easier first containers than precision lines (PLA cold cups, where clarity and lid fit matter; double-wall hot cups), and straws are already done. China dominates the category (bagasse from Guangxi/Guangdong, cups from Zhejiang and Anhui, PLA lids often Taiwan); Turkey is worth a look for kraft lines (shorter lead times); UK/EU converters cost more per unit but buy fast replenishment and a made-closer-to-home story. The practicalities to budget for:

- **Spec from our own bestseller data**, including rim diameter: an own-brand cup must fit the standard lids already in the market, and vice versa. Getting lid fit wrong is the classic first-container disaster.
- **Vet factories properly.** Alibaba / Made-in-China / Global Sources are directories, not endorsements. Real vetting: trade shows (Canton Fair, Hotelex) or verified export history and existing UK/EU customer references. Demand certificates *in the manufacturer's own name for the exact product line* and verify them on the certifier's public register (TÜV Austria, DIN CERTCO). Certificate fraud is genuinely common.
- **Compliance transfers to Afida as the importer.** Food-contact compliance (UK retained Regulation 1935/2004) with migration test reports from an accredited lab (SGS, Intertek, Eurofins); EN 13432 behind every "compostable" claim, OK compost HOME if home-compostable is claimed; **Plastic Packaging Tax: PLA counts as plastic** (compostable does not mean exempt; paper cups depend on component weight, assess per SKU); packaging EPR producer obligations once past the turnover/tonnage thresholds; product liability insurance and lot-level traceability.
- **QC and logistics.** Golden samples signed off before production; a pre-shipment inspection (QIMA or SGS, roughly £300) on every early order; buy FOB with our own UK freight forwarder rather than the factory's CIF; EORI number, correct commodity codes, postponed VAT accounting. Order-to-shelf is ~4 months (30-45 days production, 35-45 days sea freight, customs), which means forecasting demand two quarters out.
- **The money.** Plain-unit MOQs are meaningfully lower than printed ones (printed cups run 50-100k units per size; plain, far less), and branded outer cartons add little. A sensible first direct order is 3-5 SKUs, £10-20k landed, sized against proven velocity (≤ 8 weeks of demonstrated demand per SKU where possible), never a range launch. The risk is not losing the money outright; it is burying it in slow-moving pallets while the 3PL invoices arrive monthly.

Standing rules: business as usual until a SKU crosses its velocity threshold (no intermediate white-label step); each import is gated on measured sell-through, not enthusiasm; first orders sized to roughly a quarter of proven demand, never a range launch.

6. Scenarios (because a single number would be dishonest)

	Conservative	Central	Stretch
What happens	SEO gains plateau, trade wedge converts poorly, no own-brand	Plan executes, phases gate properly	Custom print takes off, own-brand lands early, outbound works
Mid-2027 run-rate	£3-4k/mo	£6-8k/mo	£10k/mo
Mid-2029 run-rate	£7-9k/mo	£20-25k/mo	£40k/mo
Mid-2031 run-rate	£10-13k/mo (~£130-160k/yr)	£55-70k/mo (~£650-800k/yr)	£100k+/mo (£1.2m+/yr)
Blended GM 2031	~32%	~42%	~45%
Net outcome	Pays its own upkeep, marginal	£120-170k/yr profit	£200k+/yr, hire #2-3

All figures are afida.com revenue only; Afida's offline book is additive to these and untouched by this table.

The base rates deserve honesty: most sub-£50k shops in a price-transparent commodity category never escape the conservative column. The two things that historically move a packaging reseller into the central column are exactly trade retention and owned product; that is why they are the plan, and why "keep doing SEO harder" is not.

7. Risks and kill criteria

- **June was noise.** If revenue is below £4k/month by mid-2027 despite the Phase 1 work, do not proceed to Phase 2 spending; re-diagnose (pricing? assortment? UK traffic quality?) first.
- **PLA regulatory risk.** A UK policy turn against industrially-compostable PLA would hit cold cups. Watch Defra/EPR signals annually; keep material mix diversified; own-brand should lean paper/bagasse-first.
- **Key-person concentration.** The whole operation is Afida leadership plus Laurent. Phase 2's outbound and Phase 3's sourcing need real leadership hours or a hire; if that time never materialises, cap ambitions at the conservative scenario and size costs accordingly, i.e. reduce, don't grow, the dev retainer.
- **Working-capital risk (own-brand).** Gate strictly on the per-SKU velocity thresholds in §5.1; first order sized to roughly a quarter of proven demand (leadership's own sizing example); never a "range launch". The straw imports already show the mild version of this failure mode: sell-through stretched from ~3 months at launch to 3-4+ as focus moved and competition arrived. Every container is a bet that demand holds for its whole sell-through window, which is why the velocity report should keep watching lines *after* import, not just before.
- **Distributor channel conflict.** Going direct or own-brand may cool the distributor relationship; sequence it after volume makes Afida worth keeping anyway.
- **Amazon temptation.** Reselling branded SKUs on Amazon is negative-margin theatre at this scale. Own-brand only, and only in Phase 3+.

8. What we deliberately do NOT do

- No new consumer-awareness content (the straws/blog lesson is paid for; 74% of impressions, ~£0).
 - No paid-spend increases before the Phase 1 scoreboard proves return.
 - No international shipping before own-brand margins exist to pay for its complexity (revisit 2029+).
 - No marketplace expansion on branded resale SKUs, ever.
 - No further consumer-UX engineering polish beyond what conversion data specifically indicates; the app is ahead of the business already.
 - No price war with Nisbets/Catering24. If a customer's only question is price, they were never our customer.
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9. Operating rhythm and the numbers that matter

Monthly, one page, same order every time (extends the existing blended scoreboard):

1. UK online revenue and orders (trend, not the month in isolation)
2. **Active trade accounts (2+ orders, store + portal) and standing-order count**, the single most important number in this plan from Phase 1 onward
3. Repeat share of revenue (target: 30% → 45% → 60% across the phases)
4. Blended gross margin (needs COGS per SKU captured; do this in 2026 so the margin levers are measurable)
5. Sample requests → first trade order conversion
6. Channel scoreboard (organic positions on the commercial term set, paid return, email revenue)
7. Cash reality: channel gross profit vs channel operating cost, distance to channel break-even

Quarterly: re-read this document against the numbers, promote/demote phases, and adjust.
Annually with Afida leadership: the working-capital and hiring decisions.

10. Immediate next 90 days (so this doesn't stay a strategy document)

1. Finish the accountability work already in flight (ads reconciliation, Datafast purchase-goal watch, consent mode v2 for ad measurement).
2. 2026-07-17 GSC pull: measure Moves 1-2, re-prioritise the SEO backlog.
3. Ship the afida.com trade page + sign-up funnelling into customer.afida.com, and the "reorder" button wherever the account lives; report "accounts with 2+ orders" monthly. Alongside: ask 3-5 existing trade clients why the portal isn't worth using, and scope what a Rekki / Procure Wizard / MarketMan supplier listing would take.
4. Wire the samples follow-up sequence and Klaviyo replenishment flows.
5. Start capturing per-SKU COGS in the admin so gross margin becomes a real, queryable number.
6. Put to Afida leadership the three questions this plan hinges on: appetite for outbound hours in 2027, appetite for £15-30k own-brand working capital in 2028, and where custom print lives (Afida vs Brand Brothers). While at it, get the offline trade book's order-size and reorder-frequency numbers; they calibrate Phase 2.